

I started my career as a corporate lawyer at one of the world's largest law firms. To be honest, I decided to go to law school to complement my Master's in Public Policy; I am one of those people who went to law school for the knowledge until I realized how expensive that knowledge was! As a result, I decided to practice law for a few years to make some money and whittle down my student loan debt. Fortunately, a good friend's father was an accountant and financial planner. He sat me down shortly after I started practicing and explained that now was the right time to start saving for retirement. Retirement was the furthest thing from my mind, but I am so thankful for Mr. Piper. He advised me to pay myself with every paycheck by investing in a variety of mutual funds and stocks of my choosing. I ended up practicing law for 10+ years and was able to save up enough to buy a 2-bedroom condo and sock away a good chunk of money for retirement. When I retired from the practice of law, I had more than enough money to self-fund the start of my company, to live and continue to invest. There's nothing like having your own money and feeling financially independent. One of the best forms of self-care is to pay yourself every pay period. Whether you invest on your own or hire someone to help you, investing for your future is not something to put off until tomorrow.

Then there's my other amazing friend, Yezmin Thomas, an 11-time regional Emmy award-winning journalist, financial coach, and founder of the Smart Dollar Challenge (yezminthomas.com), who started investing early despite retirement being the last thing on her mind. Here's what she shared: